

What Makes a Villain Truly Epic?



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Hi! I have so many things I want to talk to you about. I just finished the Percy Jackson series this weekend, and I have lots of ideas about how Percy and Greek mythology are similar and different from the *Shahnameh*. We can talk about that in my next post.

I'm also doing a cool coding camp this week where I'm learning JavaScript and some AI coding. On Saturday I went with my sister and my friend to a fun class at the Apple Store where we got to design our own superheroes. My mission was to create a superhero that rescues animals lost at sea.

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Here I am as Super Jack with a horse head and wings (so I can run and fly if I need to). I'm eating sushi (yum!), waving a Swedish flag (I'm a quarter Swedish), and saving my favorite animals (the dolphins). Ha!



Anyway, back to the *Shahnameh*. Since my first two posts talked about epic stories and heroes, I wanted to make a trilogy and talk about epic villains today!

Everyone knows that heroes are one of the most important parts of epic stories. But I think villains are just as important. Heroes need villains. And the best villains are the ones that make heroes become even greater. Without them, there wouldn't be epic stories!

As I kept reading the *Shahnameh*, I noticed the greatest villains have a lot in common. Here are the things I think make a villain truly epic:

1. Ambition

Epic villains are never happy with what they already have. They always want more. More land, more power, more kingdoms...you know.

Salm and Tur already had great kingdoms, but they wanted Persia too. They had so much ambition that they were willing to kill their own brother for it. How crazy do you have to be to do that?

I don't think being ambitious is bad because heroes are ambitious too. But villains want power even more than they care about doing the right thing. And it seems like the bigger the villain's goal is, the more epic their story becomes.

2. Pride

Epic villains think they deserve more than anyone else. They usually don't make trouble just to be mean. Most of the time they do it because they think they deserve something super important or because they just *have* to get revenge.

Like Afrasiyab, who wanted to conquer Persia. Or Salm and Tur who wanted Persia so badly that they killed their own brother Iraj, instead of sharing the kingdom. Super sad. That one terrible decision started so many years of war.

But the funny part is, these villains actually think of themselves as heroes. Afrasiyab doesn't think he's a bad guy. Salm and Tur probably don't either.

I think that's what makes proud villains so scary. A bad guy who knows they're being bad might feel guilty and stop. But a bad guy who thinks they're the good guy? They'll never stop...

3. Persistence

Epic villains almost never give up. Even after they lose a battle, they keep coming back and trying again.

Afrasiyab is the main example in the *Shahnameh*. He wants to conquer Persia so badly and invades it over and over again. Even after all the battles he loses, he refuses to stop trying. He never quits!

4. Power

Every epic villain has some kind of power, but it isn't always about being the strongest. Sometimes their power can come from words.

Some villains are powerful because they are great fighters, like the White Div. Other villains are powerful because they lead big armies, like Afrasiyab.

Then there are villains like Sudabeh and Garsivaz who use their words for power. They trick people, spread lies, and get other people to make bad choices. I think that can be even scarier than villains who fight with weapons.

5. Influence

Most epic villains don't work alone. They know how to get other people to follow them.

Afrasiyab had an entire army of Turanians fighting for him. Zahhak also had lots of people following him because they were either afraid of him or wanted power too.

These bad guys get lots of followers and convince others to help them. I think villains become a lot more dangerous when they do that.

6. Opposition

An epic villain is really good at getting in the way of a hero and the hero's goal.

Rostam wanted to protect Persia, but Afrasiyab kept invading it. Kay Khosrow wanted to bring peace, but he couldn't do that when Afrasiyab was still attacking his kingdom.

Usually villains are the ones standing in the hero's way. But sometimes things get more complicated. Like when Esfandiyar, who's a good guy, becomes an obstacle for Rostam. Esfandiyar doesn't actually want to fight Rostam, but his dad Goshtasp tells him he has to. That is one of the saddest parts of the *Shahnameh* because both heroes really don't want to hurt each other.

I think that's one of the reasons the *Shahnameh* is so interesting. Some villains are obviously evil, but other times the difference between heroes and villains in the stories isn't as obvious.

If you want a real life battle against some epic villains, check out the Shahnameh Chess game on the Epic of Kings website where you can play against Afrasiyab and his army of bad guys!

So that's the end of my trilogy about epic stories, heroes, and villains. Next time I want to compare Percy Jackson and Greek mythology with the *Shahnameh*. I think you'll be surprised by how similar (and different!) they are.

Thanks for reading. See you next time!

Jack

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